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*Food Security in Northern Malawi: Gender, Kinship Relations and Entitlements in Historical Context**

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This article examines household food security in the Ekwendeni region of northern Malawi using the concept of entitlements, set within a broader world historical framework. The bargaining approach to household gender relations is critiqued through an examination of the data. Historical relations created a gendered experience of food security in northern Malawi. Qualitative research carried out in the Ekwendeni region indicates that women have fewer entitlements within the household, at least in part due to the modified patrilineal system of the Tumbuka-speaking people with Ngoni heritage in the region. They have a higher workload in terms of household reproduction as well as agricultural and market activities. Women are responsible for caring for sick relatives within and beyond the household, which affects household food security. Wives are less likely to receive support for kin in the form of seeds, cash, land or food, in comparison to husbands, who in turn do not always give these resources to the household. Women do not have much decision-making power over major production issues. There is evidence for high levels of spousal abuse, as well as excessive use of alcohol by husbands, which also affects household food security. Wives' unequal position is thus due to a lack of entitlements, such as land, access to employment, support from kin and the state. Some differences between this area of northern Malawi and other studies from central and southern Malawi are due to the different entitlements, particularly control over land and income, which speaks to the enduring implications of different lineage systems in the region. Food security is thus affected by women's unequal access to entitlements in northern Malawi, set within a world historical framework, which is essential for understanding the broader causes of food insecurity.

Introduction

Achieving household food security, here defined as access to the amount and quality of food needed for an active and healthy life,¹ is a critical problem in Malawi. The majority of Malawians are engaged in smallholder agriculture. Maize harvests provide rural households

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1 E. Kennedy, 'Hope and Reality: Food Security and Nutrition Security for the Twenty-first Century', in A. E. El Obeid, S. R. Johnson, H. H. Jensen, and L. C. Smith (eds), *Food Security: New Solutions for the Twenty-first Century* (Iowa, Iowa State University Press, 1999), p. 264.

with the major share of their food supply, but most also rely on maize purchases.² Malnutrition, one indicator of food insecurity, is extremely high in Malawi. Approximately 25 per cent of children under five in Malawi are underweight, and almost half of Malawian children under five years old were found to be stunted in a recent national survey, both indicators of chronic under-nutrition. These statistics are almost identical to a survey conducted in 1991, suggesting no improvement in nutritional status over the last ten years.³

A 2002 famine was caused in part by floods, the government's sale of the Strategic Grain Reserve and low maize production the previous year. Maize production fell by over 30 per cent and maize prices rose by over 300 per cent.⁴ Over one-third of the population required emergency support.⁵ One dominant perspective attributes the causes of food insecurity in Malawi to increasing population, decreases in land availability and decreasing soil fertility.⁶ Food security and soil fertility management, however, are much more complex than a simple linear relationship between higher populations, less land and depleted soils. International and national policies and their historical intersection with gender relations all have implications for food security. Household members may have different levels of access and control over resources that affect food security, a difference that is often delineated by gender. Household members may use resources to improve household food security, or to worsen it. Thus, gender and intra-household relations are critical components of food security analysis.

This study examines the role of gender and household relations within a broad historical framework and uses the concept of entitlements and the bargaining approach to understand current problems with food security in one area of northern Malawi, based on qualitative research carried out in 1997. The questions that I examine are as follows.

- (1) What has been the historical experience of intra-household relations in northern Malawi?
- (2) What is the household division of resources, labour and decision-making in the contemporary Ekwendeni area of northern Malawi?
- (3) What are the current interactions between these intra-household relations and food security in the Ekwendeni area of northern Malawi?

Conceptual and Theoretical Approach

This article takes a broad historical approach to understanding food security in Malawi. The historical approach will give context to different entitlements within and between households in northern Malawi. The historical component of this article focuses on the larger area of northern Malawi, as there is limited archival material on gender relations specific to the Ekwendeni region. The concept of entitlements was originally outlined by Amartya Sen⁷ to shift the analytical focus of research on famines from food distribution to access to food. The concept highlights how hunger is not experienced equally at a global, national, regional,

2 P. Peters, *Failed Magic or Social Context? Market Liberalization and the Rural Poor in Malawi, Development Discussion Paper 562* (Cambridge MA, Harvard Institute for International Development, 1996), p. 8.

3 National Statistics Office (NSO), *Malawi Demographic and Health Survey* (Lilongwe, NSO, 2001), p. 137.

4 S. Devereux, 'The Malawi Famine of 2002: Causes, Consequences, Policy Lessons' (unpublished presentation, Lilongwe, 2003). Available on-line at <http://www.odi.org.uk/Food-Security-Forum/docs/devereux/>.

5 D. Cammock, O. Chula, S. Khaila and D. Ng'ong'ola, 'Malawi Food Security Issues Paper' (unpublished paper, Lilongwe, 2003). Available on-line at <http://www.odi.org.uk/Food-Security-Forum/docs/MalawiCIP.pdf>.

6 S. Devereux, *Household Food Security in Malawi: IDS Discussion Paper 262* (Sussex, International Development Studies, 1997), p. 5.

7 A. Sen, *Poverty and Famines: An Essay in Entitlement and Deprivation* (Oxford, Oxford University Press, 1981).

community or even household level. There are two types of entitlements: endowments (or owned assets, such as land) and exchange entitlements, which are mediated by social relations.⁸ Thus, entitlements are legally and socially defined rights to resources. Vaughan used the entitlement approach to examine the 1949 famine in Nyasaland.⁹ This study endeavours to extend the entitlement approach to northern Malawi, as well as critiquing the bargaining approach to understanding household relations. In Malawi, households with fewer entitlements – due to the broader historical processes that will be outlined – are more likely to experience food insecurity. This article will argue, however, that unequal relations *within* the household also increase the potential for household food insecurity.

Much of the literature on food security assumes that if income is increased the overall food security of households will increase, since any income produced will be shared within the household. The unitary model of the household, first outlined by Becker,¹⁰ has been criticised as an unrealistic assessment of household dynamics.¹¹ By treating the household as an undifferentiated unit, gender, age and differences of power in gender relations are ignored. In response, some theorists have used game theory to develop formal models for understanding intra-household dynamics.¹² The bargaining approach, however, rather than formal models, may be more useful in identifying complex factors, including perceptions and social norms that affect household bargaining positions.¹³ In the bargaining approach, many different factors are considered that affect women's power to negotiate with other household members: property ownership, access to employment and other income-earning means, a household's class position, access to village commons, support from kin and friends, support from gender-progressive organisations, state support, social norms and perceptions. Since they are either owned assets or exchange entitlements, these factors can be considered entitlements according to Sen's outline of the concept. Women's access to these entitlements may help to explain their unequal bargaining position within the household in a given region, as well as explain how poorer households are more likely to be food insecure. However, this article critiques the bargaining approach for not incorporating important historical and power dimensions. There are numerous interactions between entitlements at the household, community, state and market level. The bargaining approach to intra-household dynamics will help to explain the gendered experience of food insecurity in one area of northern Malawi, while the historical overview using an entitlement concept will frame the contemporary situation in a broader political context.

Historical Context

In this article the term 'northern Malawi' is used to describe that portion of the country encompassing the Northern Region, as defined by the current government of Malawi. This study was carried out in an approximately 600 km² area surrounding the town of Ekwendeni (Figure 1). Ekwendeni is a town of about 10,000 people with a small market, an agricultural extension office, several non-governmental organisations, and the Ekwendeni

8 A. Sen, 'Food, Economics and Entitlements', in J. Dreze and A. Sen (eds), *The Political Economy of Hunger, Volume 1: Entitlement and Well-being* (Oxford, Clarendon Press, 1990), pp. 34–52.

9 M. Vaughan, *The Story of an African Famine: Gender and Famine in Twentieth Century Malawi* (Cambridge, Cambridge University Press, 1987).

10 G. S. Becker, *A Treatise on the Family* (Cambridge, MA, Harvard University Press, 1981).

11 There are numerous critiques of this approach, including R. R. Wilk, 'Decision-making and Resource Flows Within the Household: Beyond the Black Box', in R. R. Wilk (ed.), *The Household Economy: Reconsidering the Domestic Mode of Production* (Boulder, Westview Press, 1989), pp. 23–54.

12 L. Haddad, J. Hoddinott and H. Alderman (eds), *Intrahousehold Resource Allocation in Developing Countries: Methods, Models and Policy* (Baltimore, Johns Hopkins University Press, 1994).

13 B. Agarwal, 'Relations: Within and Beyond the Household', *Feminist Economics*, 3, 1 (1997), pp. 1–51.

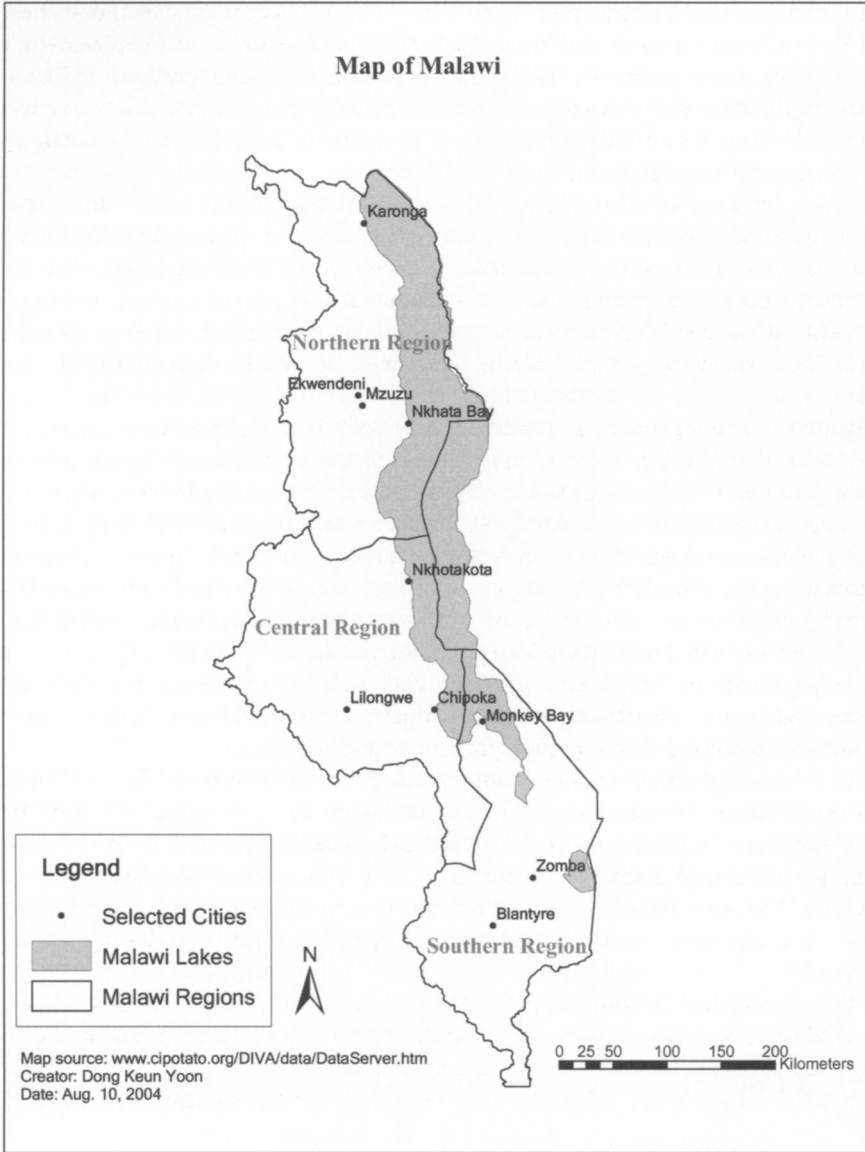


Figure 1. Map of study region.

Mission Station, which includes a secondary school, a hospital, two primary schools and a lay training centre. Ekwendeni Mission, run by the Church of Central African Presbyterian (CCAP) was originally founded by the Free Church of Scotland in 1889, and has played a critical role in the politics of the region.¹⁴ Ekwendeni Hospital, also founded in the late-1800s, now has a large Primary Health Care department that has run various development and health programmes in the area for over twenty years. As in much

¹⁴ J. McCracken, 'Religion and Politics in Northern Ngoniland, 1881–1904', in B. Pachai (ed.), *The Early History of Malawi* (Evanston, Northwestern University Press, 1972), pp. 215–236; L. Vail and L. White, 'Tribalism in the Political History of Malawi', in L. Vail, (ed.), *The Creation of Tribalism in Southern Africa* (Berkeley, University of California Press, 1991), pp. 151–192.

of central and eastern Africa, there is no clear 'tribal division' in the region, but rather histories of different lineages that dominated at different periods.¹⁵ The Ekwendeni region has historically been composed of a mix of populations from different cultures, with intermarriages taking place between Ngoni and Tumbuka-speaking peoples. Ethnic identities in the region were reinforced and reshaped considerably by mission education, political activities and migration in the region.¹⁶

For the purposes of this article, the area will be referred to as the Ekwendeni region (Figure 1). The findings from this article are not necessarily valid for all of northern Malawi, due to the special influence of the Mission on the Ekwendeni region,¹⁷ and the particular ethnic context of both Ngoni and Tumbuka peoples living in the area. This section will outline the historical roots of the gendered experience of food security in northern Malawi. The contemporary food security situation will then be discussed in its historical context.

Prior to the colonial period, a very active slave trade had disrupted community life in the region. There existed a *mélange* of different people in the area around Ekwendeni. Tumbuka-speaking peoples, loosely organised in villages with fairly autonomous village headmen, were scattered throughout the region.¹⁸ The Ngoni, themselves refugees from Zulu wars in the Natal region of South Africa, invaded in the late nineteenth century, conquered the Tumbuka in the region, established large villages and created 'buffer zones' around villages where only wild animals could live. Tumbuka were incorporated into the Ngoni settlements, and the Ngoni attempted to promote Ngoni cultural practices. Ngoni marriage practices, such as cattle payments of bridewealth (*lobola*) and virilocal residence, gradually replaced Tumbuka matrilineal inheritance and brideservice practices; although today a mixture of marriage practices speak to a modified patrilineal system.

Little is known about pre-colonial farming practices in northern Malawi (and Ekwendeni in particular) due to the lack of written records from that time. Evidence from southern Malawi suggests that farmers used agricultural systems that relied on intercropping, seasonally waterlogged areas, incorporation of crop residue, and fallowing fields to regain soil fertility.¹⁹ Women and men were both involved in agricultural production. In areas where the slave trade was active, people had to leave the more fertile land in order to avoid conflicts or capture.²⁰

Britain established Nyasaland (now Malawi) as a protectorate in 1891. Women in northern Malawi were increasingly responsible for household farming during the colonial period, while becoming more reliant on cash remittances from absent males, due to numerous colonial policies and events.²¹ The colonial government introduced a hut tax in 1892,²² which

15 H. L. Vail, 'Suggestions Towards a Reinterpreted Tumbuka History', in Pachai (ed.), *The Early History of Malawi*, pp. 148–167.

16 Vail and White, 'Tribalism in the Political History of Malawi', p. 163; J. McCracken, *Politics and Christianity in Malawi 1875–1940: The Impact of the Livingstonia Mission in the Northern Province* (Cambridge, Cambridge University Press, 1977), p. 124.

17 The Free Church of Scotland emphasised the importance of education and encouraged a Western patrilineal model of marriage in the region through the Livingstonia mission. (McCracken, *Politics and Christianity in Northern Malawi*).

18 This section on the ethnic history of the region draws on Vail and White, 'Tribalism in the Political History of Malawi', pp. 152–153.

19 Vaughan, *The Story of an African Famine*, pp. 52–60; E. C. Mandala, *Work and Control in a Peasant Economy: A History of the Lower Tchiri Valley in Malawi 1859–1960* (Madison, University of Wisconsin Press, 1990), pp. 50–60.

20 L. Vail, 'The Political Economy of East-Central Africa', in D. Birmingham and P. M. Martin (eds), *History of Central Africa, Volume 2* (London, Longman, 1983), p. 204.

21 Vaughan, *The Story of an African Famine*, p. 138.

22 Mandala, *Work and Control in a Peasant Economy*, p. 111.

led northern Malawians to seek out cash in two primary ways, both of which affected the gender division of labour: work in the estate sector of central and southern Malawi and migration to find work in other countries. In central Malawi, the 'visiting tenant' system (still in existence today), involved labourers from other areas obtaining land on estates in return for growing cash crops and selling them to the estate.²³ Visiting tenants were required to purchase all supplies on credit from the estate owner, who generally made a profit when tobacco was purchased from the tenant. Many visiting tenants were families from northern Malawi. Women from these households often provided informal labour to other farms, known as *ganyu*, in order to make ends meet under these conditions.²⁴ (*Ganyu* is broadly defined as a type of own-farm informal piecework labour, usually agricultural in nature, in which payment of food or cash is given).²⁵ Many men migrated in search of work to South Africa, Northern and Southern Rhodesia, where wages were higher. Recruitment programmes focused on northern Malawi, which came to be seen as an area of 'labour surplus' by the colonial administration, since there were relatively few estates.²⁶ Estate owners and the mining industry in these other countries hired men almost exclusively.²⁷ Several other events in the early 1900s also increased northern Malawians' reliance on labour migration: an outbreak of bovine pleuro-pneumonia in 1912 ended cattle-trading; the need for porters, food and cattle during the First World War led to a shortage of labour and an increased need for food production; the pandemic of Spanish influenza in 1919 killed thousands of Tumbuka and Ngoni; and, finally, inflation and an increase in the tax rate increased the need for cash.²⁸ All of these changes led to reduced labour inputs available for agricultural production, which decreased both food security and soil fertility. During the late colonial period the government became more focused on improving soil fertility through stringent soil conservation measures, particularly on African trust land.²⁹ The Ministry of Agriculture instigated a 'Master Farmer Scheme' to foster better-off smallholders to grow cash crops and have access to inputs, which tended to increase differentiation amongst smallholders. The government also broke up some of the estates and redistributed the land.

Government policies and international factors during the postcolonial period increased the reliance on external inputs and women's labour for maintaining smallholder agricultural production in northern Malawi. The government encouraged export crops in the estate sector, particularly tobacco, sugar and tea. At the same time, it restricted wages and discouraged trade unions. International migration was curtailed in the 1970s, which resulted in more men seeking employment in the estate sector.³⁰ Women's labour continued to be critical for smallholder agricultural production. The government crop marketing board, ADMARC, extracted a large surplus from the sale of smallholder crops. Profits were primarily invested in the estate sector and commercial banks, with a small percentage going to cross-subsidise food crops (maize and rice),³¹

23 J. G. Kydd and R. E. Christiansen, 'Structural Change in Malawi Since Independence: Consequences of a Development Strategy Based On Large-Scale Agriculture', *World Development*, 10, 5 (1982), p. 358.

24 J. McCracken, 'Planters, Peasants and the Colonial State: the Impact of the Native Tobacco Board in the Central Province of Malawi', *Journal of Southern African Studies*, 9, 2 (1982), pp. 186.

25 M. Whiteside, '*Ganyu* Labour in Malawi and its Implications for Livelihood Security Interventions: an Analysis of Recent Literature and Implications for Poverty Alleviation', *Agricultural Research and Extension Network Paper*, 99 (2000), p. 1.

26 Vail, 'The Political Economy of East-Central Africa', p. 223.

27 P. Peters, 'Against the Odds: Matriliny, Land and Gender in the Shire Highlands of Malawi', *Critique of Anthropology*, 17, 2 (1997), p. 198.

28 Vail and White, 'Tribalism in the Political History of Malawi', p. 158.

29 W. O. Mulwafu, 'Soil Erosion and State Intervention in Estate Production in the Shire Highlands Economy of Colonial Malawi, 1891–1964', *Journal of Southern African Studies*, 28, 1 (2002), p. 25.

30 M. Smale, '"Maize is Life": Malawi's Delayed Green Revolution', *World Development*, 23, 5 (1995), p. 822.

31 J. Harrigan, 'Malawi', in P. Mosley, J. Harrigan and J. Toye (eds), *Aid and Power: the World Bank and Policy-Based Lending, Volume 2, Case Studies* (London, Routledge, 1991), pp. 201–269.

largely for the benefit of estate and urban employers, although subsidies did benefit those food-insecure households that purchased maize.³² Smallholder farmers were banned from production of burley tobacco until the early 1990s.³³ Villagers' need for cash and their inability to grow cash crops facilitated the purchase of customary land by estate owners at low prices from village headmen. Estates increased from 2 per cent of the total cultivated land in 1970 to 19 per cent in 1993.³⁴

In the late 1970s, a financial crisis marked by a fall in export prices, rising oil prices, poor estate management and loss of transport through Mozambique impacted on the agricultural sector.³⁵ The IMF provided a standby loan in 1980, and imposed structural adjustment conditions along with loans from 1981 onwards.³⁶ The government's focus shifted to smallholders, and agricultural extension programmes promoted high-yielding maize varieties that required large inputs of purchased fertiliser.³⁷ Maize prices increased, in part due to the reduction in food crop subsidies, and fertiliser use rose during this period.³⁸ When maize prices later decreased, due to World Bank pressure, many smallholder farmers switched to other, potentially more profitable, crops.³⁹ The structural adjustment programmes (SAPs) led to the removal of fertiliser subsidies.⁴⁰ Fertiliser prices in Malawi have risen considerably in the last decade. Maize production has varied annually depending upon fertiliser subsidies, input packages, price changes and environmental factors. Although smallholder production overall has risen since 1994, the rise in production is largely due to increased involvement in tobacco cultivation, since the opening of the burley tobacco market to smallholder farmers.⁴¹ The primary beneficiaries of the growth in smallholder tobacco production have been better-off farmers with more land, and there is evidence for a displacement of food crops by tobacco and a worsening situation for food-insecure farmers.⁴² In the last two decades there has been a rapid increase in tobacco production in the Ekwendeni region, initially in estate production, but shifting in the last decade to smallholder production.⁴³ Smallholder farmers also increased the production of other food crops, such as millet, pulses and cassava, at the expense of maize. Thus, the share of maize as a percentage of smallholder crop plantings fell from 72 per cent in 1990 to approximately 50 per cent in 1999.⁴⁴ The food crisis of 2002

32 Kydd and Christiansen, 'Structural Change in Malawi Since Independence', pp. 360–366; Peters, *Failed Magic*, p. 20.

33 ADMARC purchased only smallholder crops at a low price and sold them at a higher price to international buyers. The estate owners could deal directly with international buyers. Kydd and Christiansen, 'Structural Change in Malawi Since Independence', pp. 366–368.

34 L. Msukwa, *Food Policy and Production: Towards Increased Household Food Security* (unpublished paper, Zomba, 1994). It should be noted that the low percentage of estate land in the 1970s was due to the breaking-up of colonial estates, which took place under government direction in the last decades of colonial rule.

35 J. G. Kydd, 'Maize Research in Malawi: Lessons from Failure', *Journal of International Development*, 1, 1 (1989), pp. 112–144.

36 Peters, *Failed Magic*, p. 4.

37 E. Cromwell, P. Kambewa, R. Mwanza and R. Chirwa, 'Impact Assessment Using Participatory Approaches: "Starter Pack" and Sustainable Agriculture in Malawi', *Agricultural Research and Extension Network Paper 112* (2001), pp. 1–12.

38 Kydd, 'Maize Research in Malawi', p. 112.

39 J. Harrigan, 'U-Turns and Full Circles: Two Decades of Agricultural Reform in Malawi 1981–2000', *World Development*, 31, 5 (2003), pp. 847–863.

40 P. Peters, *Agricultural Commercialization, Rural Economy and Household Livelihoods, 1990–1997*. (Cambridge, MA, Harvard Institute for International Development, 1999), p. 14.

41 Harrigan, 'U-Turns and Full Circles', pp. 847–863.

42 *Ibid.*, p. 858. Peters, *Developments in the Liberalization of Marketing Maize and Burley: Implications for Food Security* (Cambridge, MA, Harvard Institute for International Development, 1995).

43 Smallholder farmers were granted permission to grow the more lucrative burley tobacco in 1994. J. K. van Donge, 'Disordering the Market: the Liberalisation of Burley Tobacco in Malawi in the 1990s', *Journal of Southern African Studies*, 28, 2 (2002), p. 90.

44 Harrigan, 'U-Turns and Full Circles', pp. 852–855.

highlights the vulnerability of smallholder farmers to price changes, government policies and environmental factors.

To summarise, the colonial hut tax and other policies systematically pushed men into wage labour, while women became both reliant on and subsidised low male wages with household food production. During the postcolonial era, profits from smallholder farmers, primarily women, were funnelled to tobacco estate owners through credit and agricultural programmes. In the 1980s, structural adjustment exacerbated cash flow difficulties for smallholder farmers. Therefore, the historically constituted intra-household relations in northern Malawi are those of women carrying out the majority of food production while relying on male wage labour for fertiliser and the purchase of maize during periods of food shortage.

Entitlements, Gender and Food Security in Northern Malawi

This section will examine entitlements that affect food security for smallholder farmers in northern Malawi, and will consider gender relations that influence access to entitlements. Current analysis in Malawi suggests that food insecurity is due to low food production and limited ability to purchase food as a consequence of declining soil fertility, inadequate landholdings, inadequate labour available to smallholder farmers, and low wages in the informal economy.⁴⁵ As discussed above, all of these factors (i.e. access to land with high soil fertility, access to land, control of labour and adequate wages) are entitlements that have been shaped by historical processes. A lack of available land for smallholder production is cited as a major reason for a lack of food security.⁴⁶ One national survey estimated that 68 per cent of households cultivate less than one hectare, and only 8 per cent of households cultivate more than two hectares.⁴⁷ A high annual population growth rate, calculated at the national level at 1.98 per cent between 1977 and 1998 is one reason for reduced land availability.⁴⁸ Land shortages however, are not as acute in the north. There has been less encroachment of estates and lower population densities, calculated at 50–100 persons per square kilometre, compared to 100–200 or higher in many parts of central and southern Malawi.⁴⁹ As shown above, colonial and postcolonial policies disrupted labour allocation in the north, leaving many smallholder farmers dependent on commercial fertiliser to keep crop production up, rather than more labour intensive methods such as adding organic inputs. Soil fertility is thus also an entitlement, since it depends on access to adequate, fertile land, fertiliser, manure or labour for intercropping. Smallholder maize production fell in per capita terms from the 1960s onwards.⁵⁰ Inadequate landholdings to allow for fallowing or crop rotation, inadequate labour for carrying out intercropping activities, low access to legume seeds and limited access to cash, that is, a lack of entitlements, lead to low soil fertility for many farmers.

Many poor households seek credit to purchase fertiliser, but several factors limit their access to this entitlement. Credit was provided at very low interest rates, primarily to estate owners and other politically powerful elites during the 1970s.⁵¹ In 1994, as part of SAPs, the national credit institution was converted into a private finance company, whose high interest rates make credit unaffordable for poor farmers. No credit agency will loan money for maize

45 S. Devereux, *Household Food Security in Malawi*. (Sussex, IDS, 1997); M. Whiteside, 'Ganyu Labour in Malawi and its Implications for Livelihood Security Interventions – an Analysis of Recent Literature and Implications for Poverty Alleviation', *Agricultural Research and Extension Network Paper*, 99 (2000), p. 10.

46 D. Hirschmann and M. Vaughan. *Women Farmers of Malawi: Food Production in the Zomba District* (Berkeley, University of California Press, 1985).

47 Ministry of Agriculture, *National Sample Survey of Agriculture* (Lilongwe, Government of Malawi, 1993), p. 68.

48 T. Benson, *Malawi: an Atlas of Social Statistics* (Zomba and Washington, DC, National Statistical Office and International Food Policy Research Institute, 2002), p. 14.

49 Benson, *Malawi: an Atlas of Social Statistics*, p. 11.

50 Smale, 'Maize is life', p. 822.

51 Kydd and Christiansen, 'Structural Change in Malawi Since Independence', p. 368.

production unless the farmer is growing other cash crops.⁵² In addition, men are more likely to get access to credit for fertiliser, primarily through tobacco clubs, than women.⁵³

There are other factors limiting access to cash for fertiliser purchase. Many poor households have a cash deficit in the rainy season and have to do *ganyu*, which provides low wages or food.⁵⁴ Time spent off-farm also takes away from food production, leading to a food deficit during the dry season. A recent study found an increased income gap between the poorest households who rely on *ganyu*, and the wealthiest smallholder tobacco farmers who hire *ganyu* labour.⁵⁵ Food insecure families must sell their maize at harvest time when prices are lower, in order to pay off debts incurred from the previous season. Thus, food insecurity experienced by many smallholder farmers is due to a lack of entitlements; namely land, labour, capital, soil fertility and wages, among others.

Entitlements are also experienced differentially within households in Malawi. Vaughan⁵⁶ indicates how household relations influenced who suffered more during a famine in southern Malawi in 1949. Women were left with no productive assets much earlier, and were far more affected by the famine. Women relied on beer brewing and *ganyu* as sources of cash, and these activities were the first to decline during the famine.⁵⁷ Men were able to migrate to other areas or get food or cash from employers, while women, who had childcare responsibilities, had to sell their assets earlier and rely on government handouts. The 1949 famine highlights how gender relations affect who suffers more during periods of food shortages.

Some research has been done on intra-household control of income in various districts of southern and central Malawi, but there is a lack of sociological research carried out in northern Malawi. In the Ekwendeni region, a system of patrilineal inheritance and virilocality – in which customary land is passed through sons, and wives move to their husband's village after marriage – partially determines men's and women's access to land. Determining whether a local system is patrilineal or matrilineal depends on a number of different variables, including marriage residence, domestic authority, control and custody of children, and inheritance rules.⁵⁸ Although this fieldwork did not focus on patrilineality *per se*, limited evidence suggests that in the Ekwendeni region a modified patrilineal system exists, which incorporates some matrilineal aspects, presumably from previous Tumbuka practices.⁵⁹ In the Ekwendeni region, women can still access land through their brothers if they are divorced. Mothers tend to retain custody of their children after divorce, but the mother of the husband has a large influence in the decision-making related to childcare and feeding activities. *Lobola*, or bridewealth payments (a custom originating with the Ngoni), is still common. There is little or no evidence of brideservice or matrilocality being carried out. This system is in contrast to some areas of southern and central Malawi where matrilineal and matrilocality

52 Smale and Phiri, 'Institutional Change and Discontinuities', p. 5.

53 UNICEF and Government of Malawi, *The Situation of Children and Women in Malawi* (Lilongwe, UNICEF, 1987).

54 Peters, *Failed Magic*, p. 17.

55 *Ibid.*, p. 1.

56 Vaughan, *The Story of an African Famine*.

57 Beer brewing was banned in 1949 by the colonial government in an attempt to maintain maize supplies at the height of the famine, thereby eliminating a critical income source for many women and a type of payment for work parties in the fields during planting season (Vaughan, *Story of an African Famine*, pp. 38–39).

58 K. M. Phiri, 'Some Changes in the Matrilineal Family System Among the Chewa of Malawi Since the Nineteenth Century', *Journal of African History*, 24 (1983), p. 257.

59 A more flexible definition of matrilineal and patrilineal systems in Malawi and elsewhere is discussed in P. Peters, 'Revisiting the Puzzle Of Matriliney in South-Central Africa', *Critique of Anthropology*, 17, 2 (1997), pp. 125–146; C. Brantley, 'Through Ngoni Eyes: Margaret Read's Interpretations from Nyasaland', *Critique of Anthropology* 17, 2 (1997), pp. 147–169 and M. E. Lovett, 'From Sisters to Wives and 'Slaves', Redefining Matriliney and the Lives of Lakeside Tonga Women, 1885–1955', *Critique of Anthropology*, 17, 2 (1997), pp. 171–187.

practices prevail. Thus, in this part of the north, women have fewer entitlements, particularly land, in comparison to men, which has implications for intra-household dynamics.

Intra-household dynamics relating to income in the Ekwendeni region differ from those described in communities studied in central and southern Malawi. In one district in southern Malawi, a study found that married men give some or all of their income to their wives, who then make most decisions about household expenditure. Both men and women felt that wives were better financial managers, and would be less likely to spend money on alcohol than men. The authors suggest that a matrilineal and matrilocal system reinforces the norm of women being both 'owners of the land' and involved in income decisions.⁶⁰ Another study in one area of southern Malawi found that women controlled income from the sale of vegetables if these were grown on *dimbas*.⁶¹ In contrast, my research indicates that women in the Ekwendeni region enjoy lower access to and control over household income.

Paid off-farm work is another entitlement to which men and women have differential access. It is estimated that women in Malawi provide between 50–70 per cent of all agricultural labour.⁶² In a survey of one district in southern Malawi, 92 per cent of women farmed their own plots.⁶³ Many rural women in Malawi contribute the same number of agricultural work hours as men, in addition to an equivalent number of hours spent on household reproduction and market work.⁶⁴ Women have fewer options for earning off-farm cash income due to employer bias, low education and household duties. Women who do earn cash, do so primarily through the sales of their own produce, *ganyu* or brewing beer.⁶⁵ Thus, evidence suggests that women in Malawi generally have fewer entitlements, both historically and currently, in terms of waged labour. Women's primary sources of cash income, largely farming, *ganyu* and beer brewing, are not as reliable during periods of food shortages. In addition, the total amount of work that women carry out is greater than men on a national basis.

Methodology

This fieldwork was carried out in the Ekwendeni region of northern Malawi. The Primary Health Care department of Ekwendeni Hospital was interested in the linkages between food security, agricultural practices and household dynamics.⁶⁶ The initial selection of interviewees entailed purposive selection of information-rich cases for in-depth study.⁶⁷ The cases represent highly food-insecure households.⁶⁸ With research assistance from the Primary Health Care department, I also interviewed women who had severely malnourished

60 P. Peters and M. Guillermo Herrera, *Cash Cropping, Food Security and Nutrition: the Effects of Agricultural Commercialization Among Smallholders in Malawi*, (Cambridge, MA, Harvard Institute for International Development, 1989).

61 Streambed gardens, or gardens located near to a water source. (Hirschmann and Vaughan, *Women Farmers*).

62 A. Spring, *Agricultural Development and Gender Issues in Malawi* (Landam, Maryland University Press, 1985).

63 Hirschmann and Vaughan, *Women Farmers of Malawi*.

64 Spring, *Agricultural Development and Gender Issues in Malawi*.

65 Peters and Herrera, *Cash Cropping, Food Security and Nutrition*.

66 This research is part of an ongoing collaborative research programme with the Primary Health Care department of Ekwendeni Hospital. The majority of the research reported in this article was conducted in 1997, as part of a MSc degree (see R. Bezner Kerr, 'Food Security, Intra-Household Dynamics and Manure Use on Resource-Poor Farms in Northern Malawi' [MSc thesis, University of Guelph, 1998]). Additional fieldwork was conducted in 2000, 2001 and 2002, which focused on agricultural practices, child nutrition and food security.

67 M. Q. Patton, *Qualitative Evaluation and Research Methods* (Newbury Park, Sage Publications, 1990), p. 182.

68 The households were selected by a community nurse with many years of experience in the region. The term 'household' in northern Malawi is somewhat fluid. Based on community discussions conducted in 2001 about what is a household, the agreed local definition included: (1) man and woman; (2) man, woman and child; (3) woman and children (including polygamous households, in which each wife and her children are a separate household) and (4) man and children. Thus, an unmarried childless person is not a separate household, but grandparents and children would be either type 2, 3 or 4 (for example, grandparents and child, grandmother and child, etc.).

Table 1. Descriptive statistics of informants

Variable	Category	%	Variable	Category	%
Sex	Female	75	Land Cultivation	< 1 hectare	48
	Male	25		1–2 hectares	43
Marital Status				> 2 hectares	9
	Monogamous	66	Age	< 20 years	5
	Polygamous	16		20–29 years	36
	Separated/divorced	5		30–39 years	29
	Widowed	13		40–49 years	20
				50 + years	10

children at the Nutrition Rehabilitation Centre. Since women typically are responsible for bringing children to hospital for treatment, we broadened our selection to surrounding villages to ensure that enough men were interviewed. The villages selected were known for high levels of malnutrition, based on the number of malnourished children recorded at Primary Health Care clinics taking place in the region. We conducted 56 semi-structured interviews. Each interview was one to two hours in length, and explored themes of food security and agriculture. In 31 of these interviews, a section on intra-household dynamics was included.⁶⁹ Informants were interviewed individually, due to the sensitive nature of some of the questions. I also carried out participant observation throughout the study.⁷⁰

The sampling strategy attempted to focus primarily on food insecure households in the region, in order to examine in-depth the intra-household dynamics and agricultural production problems they face in relation to food security. Information-rich examples of food insecure households were selected in order to better understand the phenomenon of food insecurity. Owing to the purposive sampling strategy, the informants are not statistically representative of the population at large (Table 1). However, the study provides a useful insight into some of the dynamics and experiences of food insecurity that a random sample of the population might not have rendered. More women were interviewed than men, largely due to the fact that many informants were those who had brought their children to the Nutrition Rehabilitation Centre, and it is primarily women who undertake this task. The amount of land cultivated is close to the 51 per cent of households with less than one hectare, as reported in the last national survey.⁷¹ In terms of marital status, the proportion of female-headed households and polygamous households is lower than the average for the region.⁷² This study is not meant to be a quantitative examination of food security, but rather an in-depth examination of agricultural production and intra-household dynamics that relate to food insecurity, thus the issue of how representative the data are for the region and districts studied was not critical for the research design.

69 S. Kvale, *InterViews: an Introduction to Qualitative Research Interviewing* (London, Sage Publishers, 1996).

70 This study attempts to take a feminist methodological approach, an epistemological approach that recognises imbalances of power, values different types of knowledge and places oneself in the analytical process. S. Harding, 'Is There a Feminist Method?', in S. Harding (ed.), *Feminism and Methodology* (Bloomington, Indiana University Press, 1987); J. Stacey, 'Can There be a Feminist Ethnography?', in S. Gluck, and D. Patai (eds), *Women's Words: the Feminist Practice of Oral History* (New York, Routledge, 1991); L. Stanley and S. Wise, 'Method, Methodology and Epistemology in Feminist Research Processes', in L. Stanley (ed.), *Feminist Praxis: Research, Theory and Epistemology in Feminist Sociology* (London, Routledge, 1990).

71 Ministry of Agriculture, *National Sample Survey of Agriculture 1992/93*, p. ix.

72 NSO, *Malawi Demographic and Health Survey*, p. 75.

Results and Discussion

Livelihood Strategies, Food Production and Food Security

The majority (82 per cent) of the households interviewed did not have enough food stocks to last the entire year. Over half of the households deplete food stocks by December. When asked about the main problems in food production, half of the people named 'lack of fertiliser' (Figure 2). Other reasons listed were insufficient labour, poor health of the person or a relative, inadequate rainfall, lack of land and manure availability (Figure 2). All of these factors could be considered related to entitlements, as will be discussed below.

Most of the people interviewed combined agriculture with other occupations (Figure 3). The most common arrangement (33 per cent of interviews) was a combination of small business, farming and *ganyu* (Figure 2). The wide range of small businesses can be divided into three basic groups: sale of homemade products (e.g. beer, clay pots), sale of purchased products (e.g. clothing) or sale of natural resources (e.g. stones, firewood). Women tended to participate more in the sale of homemade products and natural resources, while men were more likely to participate in the sale of purchased products. This difference in market strategies suggests differential access to cash, since natural resources and homemade products do not require cash for start-up costs. In addition, there is more money in the sale of purchased products. Selling firewood has been cited by local informants as a sign of extreme food insecurity, and also runs the risk of arrest, since most of the firewood is collected from common land and so is not legal.⁷³ This finding supports the contention that access to village commons is a source of entitlement in subsistence strategies for resource-poor households.⁷⁴ Although it is not clear whether there is a gender difference in access to the commons, households with more landholdings would more likely have woodlands on their land from which they could collect firewood, and would therefore have an additional entitlement that would bolster their food security.

Ganyu was an important source of cash for over half of the informants interviewed (Figure 3). Most people did *ganyu* on other people's farms in the region, although some local tobacco estates were also a source of *ganyu*. As an unreliable, low-paying and labour-intensive income source carried out during the height of agricultural production, *ganyu* directly conflicts with household food production, while providing low compensation.⁷⁵ Both women and men did *ganyu*, although men were reported to do more *ganyu* than women. Waged employment (which differs from *ganyu* because it provides a guaranteed salary and is annual rather than seasonal) was rare, making it an entitlement to which few have access.

Labour shortages were a significant factor that limited food production and at times were caused by the conflict between the need to perform *ganyu* for cash or food and agricultural labour needs. Labour shortages were cited more frequently by female informants, and were at least partially a result of the unequal division of labour within the household, as will be discussed below. Many women described low labour contributions from husbands towards cash or food production. Often these difficulties coincided with health problems within the household or kin group. For example, women had to nurse sick relatives and were unable to

73 This is based on fieldnotes from research conducted in 2000. I did not investigate the enforcement of the prohibition, or who does the enforcement, but other studies indicate that forest management varies considerably throughout Malawi. See, for example, M. Fisher, G. Shively, and S. Buccola, 'Activity Choice, Labor Allocation and Forest Use in Malawi', *American Journal of Agricultural Economics*, (2004), in submission for publication.

74 Agarwal, 'Relations Within and Beyond the Household', p. 35.

75 R. Bezner Kerr, 'Informal Labor and Social Relations in Northern Malawi: the Theoretical Challenges and Implications of *Ganyu* Labor', accepted for publication in *Rural Sociology*.

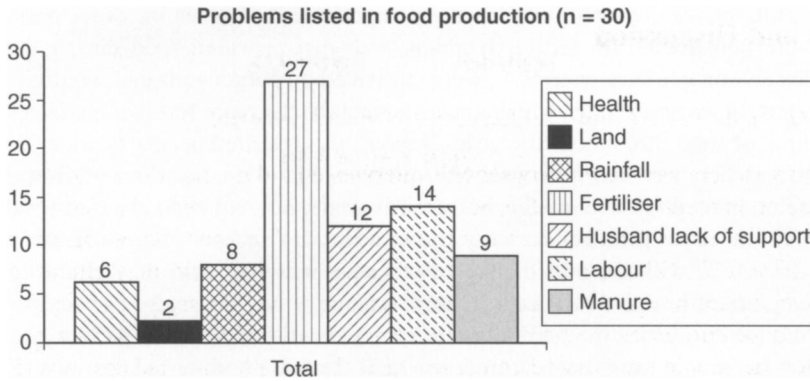


Figure 2. Problems in food production as cited by informants.

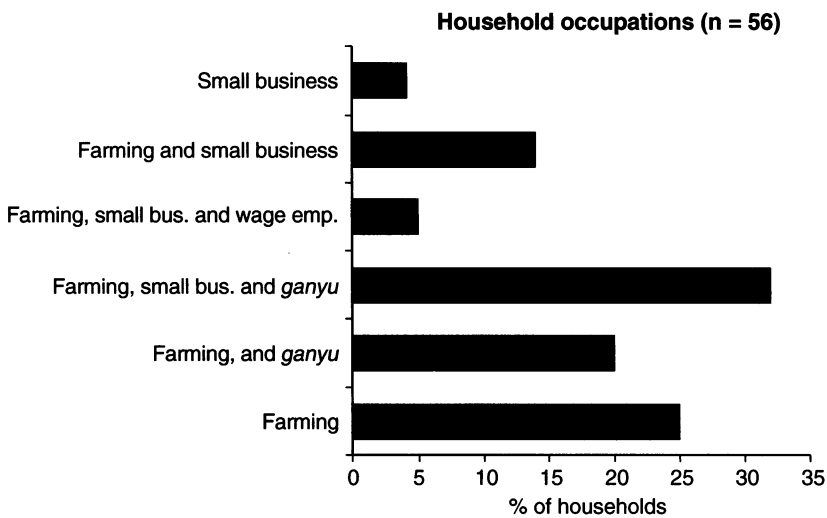


Figure 3. Household occupations, all households.

carry out all their agricultural tasks, leading to poor harvests. The costs of caring for ill relatives also led to cash shortages due to the cost of medicine and food during hospital stays, which meant that fertiliser could not be purchased. The increasing significance of HIV/AIDS in reducing labour availability may be one reason why health problems were so significant in this study.⁷⁶ Women were also expected to help with agricultural production of external kin, such as sons or brothers, and husbands if it was a polygamous household. Labour was therefore a critical entitlement, to which men tended to have greater access, both through social norms that allowed them access to the labour of their wives and female kin, and through greater access to cash to hire labour.

Only 4 per cent of households did not engage in any agricultural activity. People in agricultural households grew maize in the rainy season as their main crop, along with other crops such as pumpkins, beans and groundnuts. Slightly over one-third maintained a vegetable

76 M. M. Mtika, 'The AIDS Epidemic in Malawi and its Threat to Household Food Security', *Human Organization*, 60, 2 (2001), p. 178.

garden to cultivate crops such as green leafy vegetables, tomatoes or sweet peas. *Dambo* gardens were constructed on fertile riverbank soil, and provided food during the hungry months. Dry season gardens, or *dimbas*, were cultivated on poorer soils and required watering by hand. Thus, those households who had entitlements to the more fertile *dambos* had a more secure source of food throughout the year. *Dimbas* also required access to water during the dry season, and there were many households who did not have this entitlement. In some cases, women had attempted to have *dimbas* in previous years, but had been charged for the water by the borehole- or well-owner partway through the dry season, and could not afford to maintain the *dimba* with the added cost. In other cases, wives said they could not have a *dimba* because their husband refused to build the fence or buy the seeds, or because they did not have the time to water the garden daily. One woman had a *dimba* garden because her brother gave her manure and seedlings, her son built the fence and started the nursery, and her neighbours allowed her to use their well. Thus, to have a vegetable garden meant that one needed access to land, water, labour and sometimes cash (for seeds or water charges). Kin networks and neighbours were important sources of these entitlements. In return, the gardens were an important source of food during at least part of the year, and about one-third of households sold some of their garden crops.

Commercial fertiliser was used by most households; 69 per cent applied at least some fertiliser to their fields, indicating a high dependence on fertiliser due to infertile soil, as outlined above. Families drew on numerous sources of cash to buy fertiliser, including crop sales, *ganyu*, wages and small businesses. Approximately one in three people interviewed owned livestock (typically goats or cattle), of which slightly over half sold some livestock for cash. Forty per cent of households had chickens, typically less than ten. The higher figure of livestock compared with southern and central Malawi reflects the considerable but declining importance of cattle in the Ngoni domestic economy. Manure, obtained from various sources such as relatives' livestock or the slaughterhouse, was applied to vegetables by 50 per cent of respondents.

Relatives not residing with the individual interviewed were an important source of support for many families, particularly parents, parents-in-law or children of the person being interviewed. Kin supported households in many ways, especially by providing land, cash or labour. Seeds, manure and livestock are resources obtained from within these broader kin networks. Relatives' support often made a critical difference in changing the food security situation of the household, and can be considered a type of entitlement, since the support is a socially mediated exchange. By contrast, several informants' husbands worked in other locations but did not send regular remittances back. In several cases (9 per cent of households) the husband lived in the household but did not contribute the cash that he earned to the household. These dynamics will be discussed further below, in relation to income decision-making within the household. These findings are in contrast to the situation in southern and central Malawi, where the lack of support from husbands was rare.⁷⁷ Divorce, however, is more common in matrilineal families in southern and central Malawi, resulting in a lack of male support (through cash or labour) for many female-headed households.⁷⁸

Widows in this area of the north often mentioned land as a limiting factor. A widow loses access to her husband's land, and must ask male relatives for land, who may or may not choose to give it to her. Although most other people did not mention land availability as a constraint, they did mention poor soil fertility, which suggests that they lack entitlement to sufficient land to carry out intercropping, rotation or fallowing practices to improve soil

77 Peters and Herrera, *Cash Cropping, Food Security and Nutrition*, p. 36.

78 J. Davison, 'Tenacious Women: Clinging to *Banja* Household Production in the Face of Changing Gender Relations in Malawi', *Journal of Southern African Studies*, 19, 3 (1993), pp. 413–414.

fertility. In addition, as already discussed, many households did not have a *dimba* or a *dambo* vegetable garden, because they lacked suitable land or sufficient resources.

Many households said that one reason they had low crop harvests was due to the rains. If the rains came late, or stopped for a few weeks, the harvests were reduced. Poor families may be more affected by rainfall, since they often plant late (due to *ganyu*, late access to seed and other reasons) and do not add much fertiliser, leaving the crop more vulnerable to small changes in water supply. Thus, inadequate rainfall differentially affects households of different entitlements, and acts as a proxy 'measure' for these entitlements, such as labour and fertile soil.

Case Study

Mrs Waka has three people living with her: two children and one grandson.⁷⁹ She is married but her husband left her for a second wife and does not support her. She initially had a wage job, but fell sick and lost the job. She considers her biggest problem in food production to be lack of fertiliser. She cultivated two acres of maize and added no fertiliser or manure. The rains were poor, so there is no harvest. Last year she also had a poor harvest because she had to care for the premature twins of her daughter-in-law and therefore could not work on the garden. She harvested in June and ran out of maize in August. She has a vegetable garden near the river, which has very good soil. She grows sweet peas and several other vegetables in the garden. She both eats and sells the peas, which last about two months. She makes clay pots and sells them to buy maize when her maize is finished. She also does *ganyu* for maize.

In most cases, however, a combination of factors led to low food production. The example of Mrs Waka⁸⁰ above illustrates the interrelated nature between various entitlements and food security in northern Malawi. The need for Mrs Waka to care for kin reduced her food security, due to labour constraints and increased inputs. Further, the lack of financial support from her husband also made her situation quite tenuous. The burden of caring for several young children alone, due to these kin obligations, increased the food shortage of this household. All of these factors are socially mediated entitlements that differentially affect women in this area of northern Malawi, and leave many households food insecure. Finally, Mrs Waka herself blamed her problems on lack of fertiliser, the most common problem cited by informants in this study. The problem of 'fertiliser' thus describes a lack of access to cash, fertile land and labour, due to unequal entitlements.

Intra-household Division of Labour

Interviews indicate some clear labour patterns based on socially mediated entitlements; in some cases there is evidence of a bargaining relationship within the household, in other cases there is little dispute over the division of labour. Wives carried out almost all of the year-round tasks (Figure 4). The only year-round activities that involved husbands to any extent were *ganyu*, going to the market, and ironing.⁸¹ Husbands were reported to be actively involved in caring for the sick, but the interviews did not specify whether 'caring' referred to labour or financial help. It is likely that the informants interpreted 'care' to refer to both

79 If a woman remarries in this area, she may leave her children from previous marriages with her mother, because her new husband refuses to care for these children. This example illustrates a mixture of patrilineal and matrilineal practices in this region of Malawi, as will be discussed further below.

80 All people and places mentioned in the study are pseudonyms, to protect identities.

81 I did not investigate whether men frequently ironed throughout the year, or if ironing was only for special occasions.

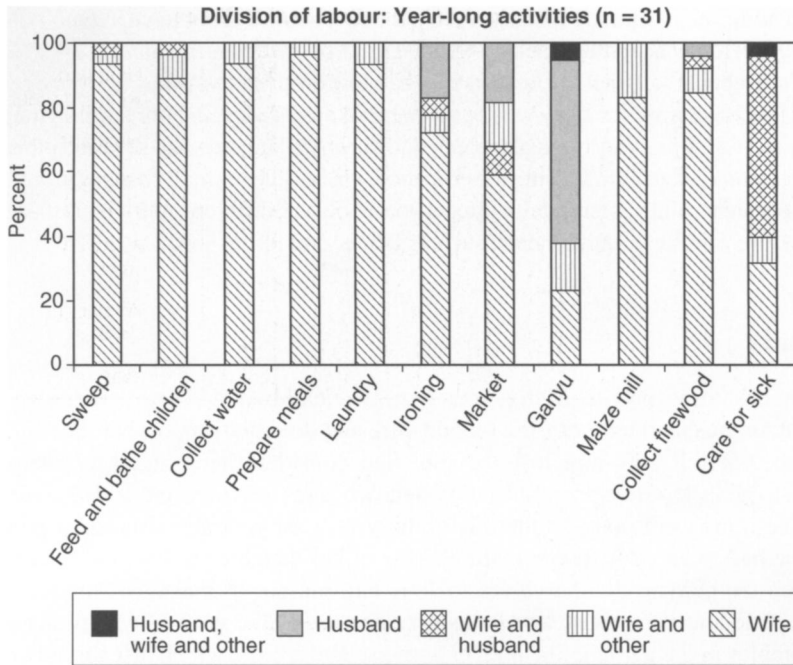


Figure 4. Division of labour in year-round activities.

labour and financial assistance, since other studies and participant observations indicate that women overwhelmingly look after the sick in this area of northern Malawi.⁸² Childcare was done by wives, older children and female relatives. Only a few households interviewed mentioned keeping cattle as a major activity, owing to the limited cattle ownership (five households) of the sample. Typically, young boys do the cattle herding in those better-off households that have livestock. Goats, owned by nine households, are not always herded, but are left free to roam. In almost half of all the married households men were involved in small businesses, *ganyu* or waged labour to generate income. Wives contributed cash in almost half of all households. In some cases this unequal division of labour led to food insecurity, since the household production activities took women away from food production or income generation, and men did not always share their income within the family. These issues will be discussed further below in relation to household decision-making.

In terms of seasonal tasks (Figure 5), men tended to do tasks of short duration. For example, men made the granary, which takes about one week, while women gathered thatch for the roof, which takes one month. In several cases the informants initially said that husbands carried out ‘strong’ tasks that involve construction, but, with probing, it became clear that both husbands and wives performed the task. For example, one man reported that he did house repair, yet later indicated that his wife and children carried buckets of water to the house to make bricks. Nonetheless, the social norm of men doing particular tasks considered ‘strong’ meant that women had to negotiate their involvement in these tasks. Hence, as mentioned above, one woman did not have a vegetable garden because her husband refused to build a fence. In other cases, the active involvement of husbands in garden preparation indicated a more co-operative household relationship. One woman reported that her husband

82 Mtika, *The AIDS Epidemic in Malawi*; Spring, *Agricultural Development and Gender Issues*.

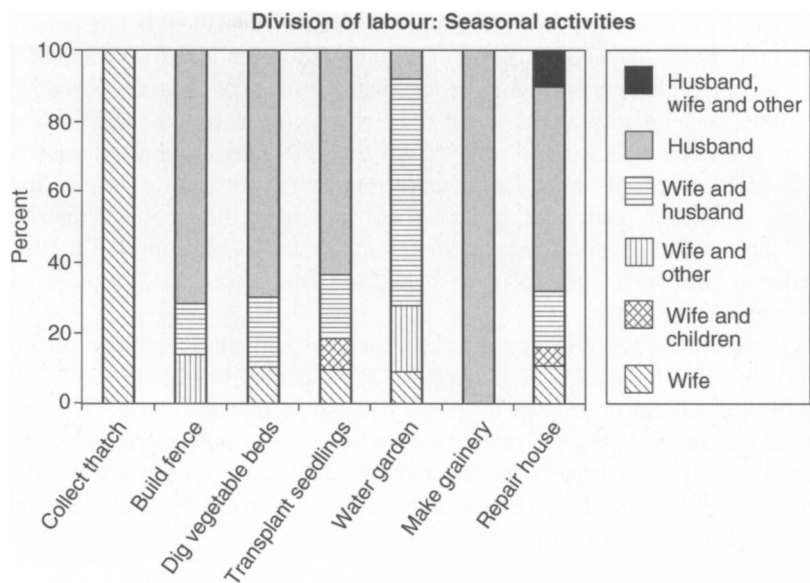


Figure 5. Division of labour for seasonal activities.

had purchased seeds, built a fence and started a nursery; she weeded and watered the garden, and sold some of the vegetables at the market. Although the division of labour was unequal, (watering and weeding are ongoing activities compared with the initial start-up of the vegetable garden), her husband's contribution was important for improving their food security.

Wives appear to play a critical role in agricultural production. The greatest variation in labour was found with the rainy season agricultural tasks (Figure 6). There were four main activities associated with rain-fed fields: ridging, planting, weeding and harvesting. Husbands ridged in all but two cases, where they had a waged job or small business. Wives ridged in all but two cases: when a plough was used, and when the wife had to care for a sick son. The mother of the husband was the relative who most often participated in ridging. Harvesting appears to be considered more the wife's task. Other people who harvested, more often

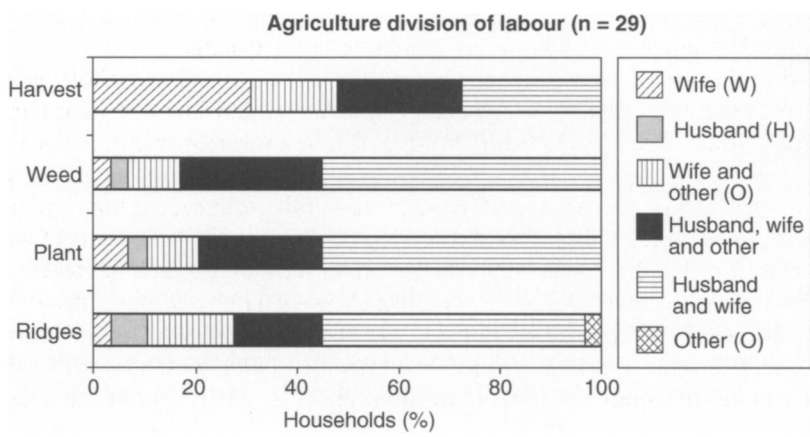


Figure 6. Agricultural division of labour.

women, included the husband's kin, hired labour, women friends and neighbours. In 15–25 per cent of households, depending on the task, only the wife, or the wife and 'other', was involved in weeding, planting or ridging. In less than 5 per cent of cases the husband did these activities alone. Several informants noted that when women had to help look after sick relatives, or when the wife herself was ill, the household food supplies went down. By contrast, several households were food secure despite the husband doing no agricultural labour. Thus, within the household, husbands are entitled to the labour of their wives and female kin; this entitlement contributes to food security, but also means that food security is jeopardised when women's labour is taken away from food production, due to illness, *ganyu* or other factors.

The evidence presented also suggested an unequal bargaining relationship within the household. In all but a few cases, wives appeared to have more work both within and beyond the household in comparison to their husbands. Husbands appear to have more leisure time than wives, particularly during the dry season. Wives rose at least an hour earlier than the husband and the children, to prepare breakfast, draw water, and so on. Evidence of the unequal bargaining relationship is also seen in perceptions of workload and decision-making dynamics, as discussed below.

Perceptions of Workload

Over half of those interviewed felt that the wife did the majority of work, while one-third felt that the husband or both of them did the most work. Interestingly, more of the men interviewed felt that both the husband and the wife did the majority of the work, while more women reported that their husbands did more work. Several comments indicated that a heavy workload, including household work is expected for women:⁸³

'What else can I do? Women are used to this work. Even if I love my wife, I can't help to cook, unless I am paid for sweeping.'

'The woman is born to work.' 'Some say that a woman should die from work.'

The fact that over half of the men readily admitted that their wives do more work suggests that gender ideology around the division of labour makes this situation acceptable, and even expected. Husbands have greater access to their wives' labour due to these social norms, suggesting an unequal relationship within the household that is more structural than bargaining in nature. Those participants who felt that husbands did more work made comments that suggest that work that generates cash or is viewed as 'heavy work' is valued more highly:

'I do business and make the granary, therefore I do more work.'

'Our husband does more work because he gives us money.'

'My husband does *ganyu*, and so he does more work.'

'I do a lot of work, but money is very important. That is why my husband does more work.'

Thus, the fact that men tend to have more access to cash gives them greater structural power within the household. The modified patrilineal system, which grants men access to land and puts married women in a different village area than their home village, may be one factor that also grants men greater structural power. Although women in northern Malawi do activities that generate cash, men still consistently have more access to wage labour and capital, or the means of production. Thus, tasks done by men are more highly valued.

83 These are paraphrases from the interviews, which were conducted in Chitumbuka.

In addition, tasks that are usually done by women, such as harvesting, are considered 'light', while making ridges, thought of as a more 'male' task, is considered harder. Hence, although women are supposed to do more work than men, their work is viewed as 'easier' within the culture. Other tasks might be seen as 'male' despite female involvement. Women might carry water for house repair but men who mould bricks are seen as doing the 'work'. Thus, the perception of who does more work is mediated by cultural constructions of gender and work and by the broader global historical factors that structure who has access to the means of production, as well as what kind of work is valued. Although women may have some bargaining power (for example, husbands building fences for the vegetable garden), there are structural, historical contingencies that limit women's bargaining power within and beyond the household.

Decision-Making within the Household

The interviews included several questions about decision-making on various aspects of food security and production.⁸⁴ What crops to plant had a variable decision-making pattern. In some cases the wife decided to plant one crop and the husband another. The decision to grow tobacco seemed to be almost entirely a husband's decision, most likely due to men's greater access to credit and tobacco clubs for fertiliser, pesticides and seeds, as well as social norms that assume men are tobacco farmers. The decision to purchase fertiliser was almost always made by the husband. Control of livestock was also largely in the hands of the husband or his kin (i.e. father or brother), which is different to studies from districts in southern and central Malawi, where women had more control over small livestock.⁸⁵ These decision-making factors should be highlighted, since intercropping legume crops, fertiliser-use or access to sufficient manure are major aspects of maintaining soil fertility and crop yields. A husband's decision to invest most of the fertiliser into tobacco meant that he also controlled the income from that crop sale, since he was likely to be the person who sold it to the tobacco trader or on the auction floor. It also has implications for food production, because tobacco is a very labour-intensive crop, and women are usually involved in weeding, harvesting and grading tobacco. Thus, women's bargaining power within the household to utilise income and labour to improve food security was compromised by unequal entitlements to cash and credit, and social norms that led to men controlling income from tobacco sales.

In 42 per cent of the interviews, wives did not know their husband's income. In polygamous households, 50 per cent of the wives did not know their husband's income. One woman said that she cultivates tobacco, and she quarrels with her husband over how he spends tobacco earnings. She did not know how much is earned or how tobacco earnings are spent. Several wives said that their husbands were 'harsh' and not willing to give more money. Other women said that they felt they did not receive enough money, but felt that they could not do anything about their situation. One woman said that she didn't agree with her husband's decisions about selling livestock or spending money, but she could not do anything. In this case, the husband also took money that she earned from crop sales. In two-thirds of households, women reported that they controlled income from their own crop sales,

84 People did not respond as easily to this section of the interview. Most participants simply stated 'husband', 'wife' or 'both' without elaboration. We were unable to get a clear picture of the decision-making dynamics within households, and it was not clear if the 'ideal' answer was given rather than the reality. Decision-making is a complex phenomenon that cannot always be understood in an interview context, and this shortcoming is acknowledged.

85 P. Peters, 'The Links Between Production and Consumption and the Achievement of Food Security Among Smallholder Farmers in Zomba South', in L. Msukwa (ed.), *Report of the Workshop on Household Food Security and Nutrition* (Zomba, University of Malawi, 1988).

but these sales were usually small, and the dynamics may be more complex, as will be discussed below. Clearly, men exerted considerable control over the majority of cash income in households and women were not always able to influence their decisions, in contrast to studies of areas in southern and central Malawi.

Alcohol Use and Spousal Abuse

An incident occurred in the community that caused us to add questions to the interviews about alcohol and physical abuse. A man came home drunk, and tried to take money from his wife, who refused. He beat her up and threw her out. When I asked my colleague about this story, she confirmed it and said that this type of incident is quite common. The results indicate that frequent alcohol use by husbands⁸⁶ is common, despite opposition by over 75 per cent of wives. The term 'frequent' refers to daily drinking for several hours, often to excess. Several wives stated that they wanted their husbands to stop excessive drinking, but felt unable to exert any influence. One woman, according to her husband, had stopped cooking for him because he drank so much. Husbands justified their alcohol use with comments such as 'it is good for a man to drink' or 'when I drink I forget my problems'. Alcohol use was by far the most commonly stated marital dispute. In several cases, husbands in very food insecure households drank frequently. This use of household income clearly compromises a household's ability to be food secure.

Physical abuse of wives was reported to occur in 44 per cent of households, and in 24 per cent there were frequent beatings reported. Both men and women reported wife beating. One group interview, conducted with thirteen men, resulted in an animated discussion about whether they should beat their wives. Several men stated that women get 'proposals' from other men, and therefore husbands have to beat them in order to prevent this or punish the wife. Comments from other men and women suggest domestic violence is almost a social norm in this area of northern Malawi:

'Sometimes my friends are beaten by their husbands. Sometimes my husband beats me.'

'Wives can be rude sometimes, and you need to beat them.'

'When she [his wife] is foolish I beat her.'

'My husband beats me a lot when I haven't washed clothes, or fed the child.'

In a few cases the informant directly related the physical abuse to alcohol use – that is, husbands returned from drinking, and beat their wives. There were, however, many cases where husbands did not drink yet did physically abuse their wives.

Within this context, husbands control many decisions about income and agriculture, and they exert power in many ways. Wives may have control over which crops to grow and how to spend their own income, although some husbands take money from their wives. Wives openly dispute some decisions made by husbands, particularly regarding alcohol use or insufficient funds given to the household, but they appear to have few avenues to change their situation. The high level of physical abuse clearly creates a climate of fear and uncertainty for wives. Thus, to characterise the household relationship as simply that of 'bargaining' ignores the broader structural context that gives men more access to entitlements and in which social norms reinforce unequal power relationships within the household. Although there is some evidence of bargaining – such as wives hiding their money, or insisting that their husbands do not drink – the overwhelming majority of households have unequal relationships in terms of

86 In no cases were wives reported to drink.

Table 2. Categories of food security

Category	1: Highly uncertain food security	2: Uncertain food security	3: Border	4: Food secure	5: Highly food secure
% Households	18%	30%	13%	25%	14%
Characteristics	<i>Ganyu</i> important source of cash and food; low support from kin networks.	Small business and <i>ganyu</i> important; low support from kin networks.	Changes in a few variables could change food security status.	Crop sales and small business important source of cash. Kin networks useful.	Access to wage labour. Crop sales and small business important. Wide source of kin networks. Large land holdings.

$n = 56$; note that a purposive sampling procedure was used to select food insecure families.

labour, decision-making and division of resources between husbands and wives, and in many cases this unequal division worsens household food security.

Key Food Security Entitlements

Several key entitlements influence food security: access to a secure cash source, labour, kin networks and intra-household control of income, as indicated in the categorisation of the informants according to food security status (Table 2). As outlined above, men systematically have greater access to cash and credit, through wage labour and programmes that give more credit to men. Men are also more likely to be estate workers. Women smallholder farmers are more likely to rely on *ganyu* as a source of cash, and have to provide *ganyu* during the critical agricultural season, when wages are depressed, and they are without food sources, putting them in vulnerable bargaining positions with employers. Wealthier smallholder tobacco farmers benefit from this vulnerable group, who provide inexpensive labour during the peak agricultural season. By providing *ganyu*, poor households take their labour away from their own food production, thereby resulting in them having to sell maize much earlier on, when prices are lower. Large landholders, by contrast, are able to store maize until the peak shortage period, when prices are inflated. Household dynamics, including higher workloads for women, spousal abuse and excess spending on alcohol, are indicative of these broader unequal power relations.

Conclusion

The findings reported here on intra-household relations for food-insecure households in the Ekwendeni region of northern Malawi have several points in common with studies from central and southern Malawi. According to this study, women are the critical labour source for food production. When men did not participate in agriculture, many households still produced sufficient food. Households were often food insecure where wives had many small children and no alternative kin networks or hired labour to rely upon. The study showed that health plays an important role in determining household food security, and health problems are an important source of agricultural labour shortages. In several cases, women had to care for sick relatives, resulting in reduced food production. In other cases, women's *ganyu* work took them away from farming, reducing overall food security. As in other studies of food security in Malawi, kin relations also play a critical role. Households with access to kin's resources, land or labour have improved food security.

Some important differences can be noted between this study's findings and others from areas in central and southern Malawi. In the Ekwendeni region, husbands and wives are the most common 'agricultural team' and the husband's female relatives are also important in agricultural production. The patrilineal and virilocal inheritance system gives more power to husbands in decision-making processes in the Ekwendeni region compared with household studies in districts of southern and central Malawi. Ekwendeni men have more control over their wives' income than is reported in studies from districts in southern Malawi. Alcohol use and domestic violence are rarely discussed in the literature on regional food security, and high rates of both alcohol use and wife beating reported in the study area reflect the high degree of control that some husbands exert over wives. Although matrilineality may be associated with a higher frequency of divorce in southern Malawian households, the increase in labour availability in food-insecure male-headed households in the Ekwendeni region due to the presence of a male is minimal. The potential for physical abuse and wasted resources reported in many households offsets the labour provided by husbands. This study supports the argument that the persistence of matrilineality in the south affords women greater entitlements in terms of access to land and access to kin relations if a marriage breaks down.⁸⁷ Nonetheless, overall land restrictions in the south and central areas may leave households in the north in a better food security position overall, despite the patrilineal system, due to generally easier access to land. An observed increase in migration from southern and central Malawi to the Ekwendeni region of northern Malawi supports this suggestion, but further studies about the gender and food security implications of such migration from a wider range of households and regions in Malawi are needed. In addition, the small sample size, limited and particular historical circumstances of the study area, and the fact that most of the families included in the study are food-insecure, limits the broad generalisations that can be drawn from the findings.

In northern Malawi, broader historical relations helped to create and reinforce the unequal power relations at work in the household. The bargaining approach to examining intra-household relations, although identifying the co-operative or conflictual nature of household relations, does not describe many of the structural aspects of household relations in northern Malawi. This study has emphasised the importance of situating unequal gendered household relations within a broader world historical framework. A focus on low soil fertility as a key cause of food insecurity in Malawi ignores the complex interactions outlined above. The problem of 'fertiliser', as named by smallholder farmers in the study, is one of unequal historical global relations that lead to a lack of entitlements in cash, labour, land or kin networks for women farmers, to the detriment of their families.

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87 Davison, 'Tenacious Women', p. 420.